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India's women's ODI World Cup win has underlined the explosive growth of the sport in recent years. With non-cricket men's sport long in the shadow of cricket, does a similar fate await non-cricket women's sport in India?

On the morning of November 3, as always, Pritam Rani Siwach began the warm-up session at the hockey academy she founded in Sonipat. Several members of the Indian women's hockey team learned their trade here, and the academy enjoys a well-earned reputation as one of the country's finest for women's hockey.

Yet, as Pritam, a former Commonwealth Games gold medallist turned Dronacharya Award-winning coach, soon realised, hockey was not on top of her trainees' minds.

"I asked them, how many of you watched

the match yesterday? And all the girls put their hands up. I'd myself been watching the match the previous evening, and so we talked about it and what a big thing it was for women in India," Pritam tells *Sportstar*.

The match she referred to was the final of the Women's Cricket World Cup between India and South Africa in Navi Mumbai, which the host won to claim its first-ever world title. Coach Pritam and her pupils were far from the only ones who watched it. About 185 million viewers streamed the final, and another 92 million watched it on TV. That is roughly the same number who tuned in for the 2024 men's T20 World Cup.

These are remarkable numbers. In Indian sport, it has long been accepted that no sport draws eyeballs like men's cricket. Those

Growth at the centre, strain at the edges

Women's cricket is booming after India's World Cup win. **The surge is real.** So is the question it raises. Where does this leave the rest of India's women athletes?

